frame through which to understand its world view and how this has evolved over the years. Now is an opportune moment to do so, since the CPC under President Xi Jinping released its Resolution on the Major Achievements and Historical Experience of the Party over the Past Century on 11 November 2021. It is only the third time that such a Resolution has been adopted. The first was in 1945, under the leadership of Mao Zedong, after he had carried out extensive purges in the Party and established his undisputed leadership. The second was adopted in 1981, after the end of the Cultural Revolution (1966–76), the death of Mao and the ascension of Deng Xiaoping as the top leader. Each of these Resolutions is a form of rewriting of history. They tell a story of shifting leadership strategies, the reading of the domestic and external situation to which the Party was responding, and how it intended to ensure that it continued to have the mandate to rule Tianxia, or 'All Under Heaven'. I will use the frame provided by the Resolutions to make sense of what is a complex and often opaque history of the CPC.

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The first of the CPC Resolutions, the Resolution on Certain Questions in the History of Our Party, was adopted by the enlarged Seventh Plenum of the Sixth Central Committee of the CPC on 20 April 1945. It covered the period since the birth of the Party in 1921 to the year 1945, when the Red Army was on the threshold of intensifying the civil war with the KMT and capturing power over the whole of China. This twenty-four-year span was described as the struggle for New Democracy, and this period can be further broken down into three distinct historical periods – the First Great Revolution (1924–27), the Agrarian Revolution (1927–37) and the War of Resistance against Japan (1937–45).

The First Great Revolution referred to the brief period when the CPC and the KMT collaborated together to defeat the various warlords and regional satraps dominating various parts of the country. The major military operations were under the command of Chiang Kai-shek, who had succeeded to the leadership of the KMT established by Sun Yat-sen. These operations began from the southern town of Guangzhou, which was the